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THE ULTIMATE WARRIOR

More than any champion in tennis history, Rafael Nadal exemplified the Greek philosopher Heraclitus's aphorism — **'Character is destiny'.**

Paul Fein



outhful exuberance fuelled a record-smashing career that captivated the sporting world for 22 years. Bouncing up and down during the pre-match coin toss, Rafael Nadal resembled a boxer primed for a title fight.

His zig-zag sprint to the baseline for the warm-up warned opponents of his boundless energy. His bulging biceps delivered topspin forehands so ferocious and relentless that a rival likened the experience to 'Chinese water torture'. His muscular legs propelled him so swiftly that he could turn defence into offence with a single spectacular shot, and his rugged torso perfectly complemented his die-hard competitiveness.

This good-looking Spanish left-hander made his foes look bad for as long as it took. If he suffered for hours, they would suffer even more. Those few who managed to upset him often had little left for their next match. Either way, he broke down their bodies, spirits, or games with repetitive brutality. At Roland Garros, the incessant body punches earned him an astounding, unbreakable record of 14 titles and the honorific title of King of Clay.

« I play every shot like my life depends on it. It is suffering, but at the same time it's enjoyable, because that's what we do — Rafael Nadal »

